

A Long Weekend of Despair

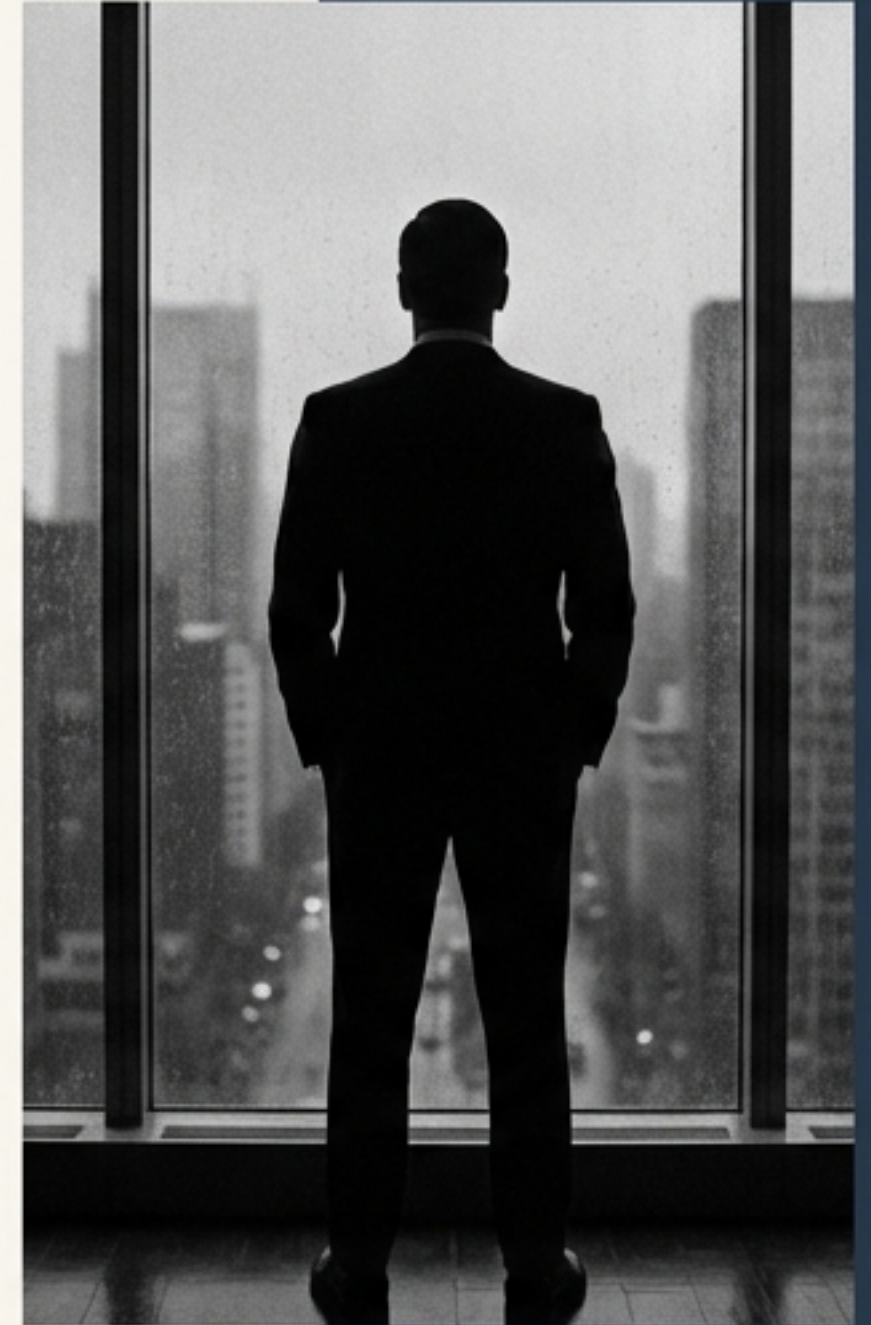
How Episode 10 of *Mad Men*'s First Season Became the Pivotal Moment in Don Draper's Unraveling



More Than an Episode, A Turning Point

The final arc of *Mad Men*'s first season is a study in the collapse of a carefully constructed identity. While Don Draper's secrets simmer throughout the season, Episode 10, "Long Weekend," is the moment his private, existential despair becomes the undeniable narrative engine. It is here that his compulsive need for escape fully manifests, setting the stage for the catastrophic personal fallout that will define the season finale.

This presentation examines the pressures leading up to "Long Weekend," dissects the episode itself, and traces the direct consequences of its central crisis.





The Hidden Man: A Past Built on Trauma

Source Episode Focus: S1 E8, "The Hobo Code"

- Flashbacks to Don's youth as Dick Whitman reveal the origins of his emotional isolation and sense of alienation.
- His encounter with a hobo establishes a core worldview of rootlessness and the need to constantly move forward, severing ties.
- This 'shadowy past' is the source of the 'existential despair' that drives his adult actions and his carefully fabricated identity.

The Ascending Woman: Forging a New Path

Source Episode Focus: S1 E8, “The Hobo Code” & S1 E9, “Shoot”

- Peggy Olson's arc is a direct contrast to Don's stasis. She transitions from a “naive secretary” to a professional with “creative and business aspirations.”
- **The Belle Jolie Pitch:** In “The Hobo Code,” she delivers successful copy for Belle Jolie lipstick (the “Mark Your Man” concept), confirming her shift in status to copywriter.
- **A Conscious Rejection:** Peggy's ambition deliberately sets her apart from the expected 1960s path of marriage and motherhood, establishing her as a disruptive force within Sterling Cooper.





The Gilded Cage: Illusion of the Suburban Marriage

Source Episode Focus: S1 E9, 'Shoot' & S1 E11, 'Indian Summer'

- Betty Draper's life as the “1960s ideal housewife” in Ossining is a facade that masks deep internal turmoil.
- Her narrative is defined by themes of “loneliness and trauma,” exposing her marriage to Don as an “illusion” he desperately tries to uphold.
- While Don's despair leads him to escape, Betty's is largely internalized, manifesting in a quiet crisis within the home.



‘Long Weekend’: A Relentless Pursuit of Escape

Source Episode Focus: S1 E10, ‘Long Weekend’

- The episode centers on Don's use of the weekend to pursue adultery, continuing his pattern of 'unfaithfulness to his family.'
- His mistress, the beatnik artist Midge Daniels, offers a temporary escape from his highly calculated identity and fabricated suburban life.
- Crucially, his actions are not about pleasure, but are a response to his 'existential despair'—a compulsive need for new romantic partners who offer momentary affirmation.

An Anatomy of Despair

S1 E10, "Long Weekend"



Private Crisis vs. Public Success

The episode masterfully contrasts Don's professional charisma and success with his profound private despair and deepening loneliness.

The Hollow Center

The Sterling Cooper office environment, with its male-dominated, sexist atmosphere and excessive drinking and smoking, is shown to offer no real solace. It is a performance, not a community.

Fractured Lives

The episode deepens the portrayal of the existential crises faced by all characters in their quest for happiness, showing how each is fundamentally alone in their struggle.



The Lie Is Breached: A Stolen Identity Revealed

Source Episode Focus: S1 E12, "Nixon vs. Kennedy"

The Revelation

- **Fact:** Richard "Dick" Whitman assumed the identity of his Commanding Officer, Lieutenant Donald Draper, during the Korean War.
- **Motive:** This act allowed him to desert the army and create a more successful and prestigious life built entirely on deception.

Context: Set against the 1960 U.S. Presidential Election, the episode mirrors the nation's own identity crisis with Don's personal one.



The Ghost of Adam: The Human Cost of Deception

Source Episode Focus: S1 E13, "The Wheel"

The News: Don is confronted with the traumatic consequence of maintaining his stolen identity when he learns his younger brother, Adam Whitman, has died by suicide.

The Connection: Don had previously given Adam \$5,000 to permanently disappear from his life, a choice made in episode "5G" to protect his lie.

The Realization: The knowledge of Adam's death forces Don to feel responsible, underscoring the profound human cost of his fabricated existence.

The Perfect Pitch for a Broken Life

Source Episode Focus: S1 E13, "The Wheel"

The Scene: Don Draper delivers his most iconic pitch of the series for the Kodak slide projector, which he rebrands "The Carousel."

The Message: He sells the device not as technology, but as a nostalgic "time machine."

Key Quote: *"It takes us to a place where we ache to go again... a place where we know we will be loved."*

The Method: In a moment of creative brilliance, he uses his own family photos to power the presentation, selling an idealized version of a life he is actively destroying.





A Tainted Triumph

Source Episode Focus: S1 E13, 'The Wheel'

The Illusionist's Masterpiece: The pitch is a work of genius, moving Harry Crane to tears and securing the account. It solidifies Don's status as a master of advertising.

The Tragic Irony: The viewer knows the happy family life projected on the screen is a lie. Betty's trust is gone, and the photos represent a nostalgia for something Don himself cannot access or sustain.

The Central Conflict: This moment perfectly encapsulates Don Draper's core conflict: he can successfully sell the American Dream to others, but he cannot live it himself.

'Don't Think Twice, It's All Right'

Source Episode Focus: S1 E13, 'The Wheel'

The Final Scene: Following his professional triumph, Don races home, hoping to share the Thanksgiving holiday with the idealized family from his pitch. He finds the house dark and empty.

The Closing Music: Bob Dylan's "Don't Think Twice, It's All Right" plays as Don sits alone on the stairs.

Thematic Significance: The song underscores his "conflicted desires for abandonment and connection" and the melancholy of his failure. He has achieved everything he thought he wanted, only to be left completely alone.

The Wheel and The Carousel



The musical choices of the final episodes underscore the season's circular tragedy. The end credits music for "Long Weekend" (E10) and "Nixon vs. Kennedy" (E12) is David Carbonara's "The Carousel." This motif finds its ultimate, ironic expression in Don's triumphant pitch in "The Wheel" (E13). He sells the Carousel as a device for recapturing love and connection, yet his own journey through the season's final arc—a wheel of despair, deception, and consequence—leaves him with neither. The despair of that "Long Weekend" was not a fleeting crisis, but the engine of his fate.